



YOU ARE **15 WEEKS AND 4 DAYS**

171 days to go

YOUR BABY TODAY

In this 2-D ultrasound, the top of the baby's head is in shadow, although the hand can be seen in front of the face. All the bones are growing and maturing at this stage of pregnancy.

“Your baby's skin is still transparent and there is little fat lying beneath it at this stage of the pregnancy.”

Your baby's skin is made from three layers. The outer layer is the epidermis, and beneath this lie the dermis layer and the subcutaneous layer. The epidermis started as a single layer of cells but is now three or four cells thick. The most superficial layer of epidermal cells flatten but do not harden until much later.

The dermis is made from connective tissue comprising collagen (90 percent) and elastin fibers that allow for stretch and resistance. Within the dermis are blood vessels and nerves that support the epidermis and provide sensory feedback. At first, the junction between the dermis and epidermis is smooth, but dermal ridges form and it becomes increasingly irregular.

At the same time your baby starts to develop hair follicles. There is no significant subcutaneous fat present at this stage and the skin is almost transparent. Fat plays a part in temperature control and acts as a barrier to the passage of water. These barriers are not yet in place so the skin is still very permeable.

PREECLAMPSIA

Low-dose aspirin may reduce the risk of preeclampsia in women at the highest risk. Some research has shown that mothers who previously had severe early preeclampsia who take low-dose aspirin (81 mg daily) can lower their risk of getting it again. But don't use aspirin unless directed by your doctor, since it can cause serious side effects.

FOCUS ON PARTNERS

Your partner may have mixed feelings about her changing shape. She may at times appear to be a “pregnant goddess” who enjoys the fact that she's carrying a child. When she feels this way, she may seem strong and content.

However, at other times, rather than loving her belly she may feel down about gaining weight and losing her body shape. When some fashion magazines show extremely thin women as a symbol of “beauty,” it is little wonder that the arrival of the belly can trigger a number of